



Enduring reminder

A student organization called Voices in Vital America first issued these bracelets in May 1970 as part of their campaign to ensure that POWs would not be forgotten. Those who wore the bracelets vowed to leave them on until the soldier, or their remains, were returned.

Vietnamese POWs in the South

The US military did not hold Vietnamese POWs—these were held by the South Vietnamese—and North Vietnam did not make its own prisoners or missing an issue in the peace negotiations, even though their numbers were far greater.

The North Vietnamese representatives in Paris sometimes casually mentioned they had many more missing than did the United States, but the government in Hanoi simply labeled their missing as “martyrs of the revolution” and demonstrated no formal interest in their fate.

After interrogation by American intelligence, all North Vietnamese and Viet Cong prisoners were placed under the jurisdiction of the ARVN military police. The South Vietnamese Ministry of the Interior operated four prisoner of war camps, one in each military region. Conditions in these camps were harsh and degrading.

Communist political operatives who were not soldiers were placed in a number of local jails or in the infamous Tiger Cages on Con Son Island. Originally forming part of a French colonial prison, the Tiger Cages were only 5 feet (1.5 m) square and 9 feet (2.7 m) high with an open roof of metal bars. No North Vietnamese soldiers—except for some POWs convicted of murder in prison camps—were held at Con Son. Conditions at the prison were so terrible that in July 1970 the Red Cross declared it in violation of the Geneva Convention prohibiting inhumane treatment of prisoners. Reports on the prison helped to convince the US Congress to begin to curtail aid to South Vietnam—a significant turning point in the war.